

Handycam Gang

Young orphans at a village near Kolkata take on the world with a shared handycam and embark on an award-winning spree at international film festivals

Bihar
WEST BENGAL

KOLKATA

Orissa



SAIFUL (EXTREME LEFT)
WITH THE OTHER
FILMMAKERS

| By Abhijit Dasgupta |

They are not exactly slumdogs but they certainly are destitute. They were not lucky enough to win Oscars, but have won eight international film awards in seven countries. Armed with one lone handycam, these twenty-odd children—all orphans—have been making award-winning human rights films. With help from the Centre for Communication and Development (CCD), based at Madhyamgram near Kolkata, these children make a film for just between Rs 15,000 and Rs 20,000. The organisation was founded in 1979 to take care of children orphaned by the devastating floods of 1978. Swapan Mukherjee, head of CCD, says: "Many children have become tutors with us while others have found jobs elsewhere." Now, films made by these children have won prizes at the Chicago Film Festival and childrens' international film festivals in Greece, Italy, Tehran, Cyprus and Sydney.

Rinku Mondal, Saiful Mondal and Biswanath Kisku are CCD's prized filmmakers. Rinku has not touched the handycam for the last one month, however, as he is preparing for his Class X examinations. Saiful, 15, who

has seen *Slumdog Millionaire*, says: "We will get our breaks too." The children developed their passion for film-making from Mukherjee who used to make short films on human rights for NGOs and send them abroad. Mukherjee says: "I organised workshops for them to pick up the technicalities, which they did very fast."

The children started off with making short films about things that appealed to them. Saiful says: "Uncle Swapan would ask us to write a story and shoot it. We could only think of filming hide-and-seek, chocolates and other trivia which were acted out by other children." He is keen to learn more about this art and take up making films after he completes his studies. The trips that the children undertook to foreign lands have been "eye-openers", very much like dreams which, they say, they will not forget easily. Saiful, who adores Satyajit Ray and has seen all of his films, is not a big fan of foreign films. He adds: "The language is difficult and we can't learn much from the skills of foreign directors as we are self-taught." Clearly, these celluloid adventurers seem set for greater glory. ■